the things of the present world', which suggests a strong sense of an afterlife and karmic punishment and reward. He documents 'nine methods of showing outward respect' that Indians use with each other, such as using soothing words to make requests, 'joining the hands and bowing low', 'bending the knee', 'a prostration', etc. State governance, he writes, is 'founded on benign principles', does not subject people to forced labour, and 'taxes on the people are light'. 'In their rules of government, there is remarkable rectitude, whilst in their behavior there is much gentleness and sweetness.' There are a few 'criminals and rebels' but they are 'only occasionally troublesome'.

However, such favourable generalizing about India as a whole has frequent exceptions in his regional assessments of people. While Xuanzang says nice things about many groups—people are 'simple and honest' in Multan, 'virtuous and docile' in Malwa, 'courageous and truthful' in Kanchipuram—the 'exceptions' occur twice or thrice as often. They seem like dyspeptic verdicts, offered without explanation. For instance, in Baltistan, people are 'rough and rude in character; there is little humanity or justice with them; and as for politeness, such a thing has not been heard of'. In the country of Kuluta (Kullu district in present-day Himachal Pradesh), he finds people 'coarse and common', 'much afflicted with goitre and tumours', and their nature 'hard and fierce'. Men have a savage disposition in Garhwal. They're 'vehement and impetuous' in Kalinga (Orissa), 'crooked and perverse' in Bharuch (Gujarat), 'fierce and impulsive' in Andhra country, 'dissolute and cruel' in Chola country, and 'given to indulgence and debauchery' in Sindh. In a kingdom near Varanasi, men are 'naturally fierce and excitable', and so on.

These pronouncements do not depend on whether a country has more Buddhists or 'heretics' (i.e., of Brahminical, pagan or other beliefs). He even spent many months studying at Buddhist monasteries in several of these regions and must have interacted with many locals. Did some bad experiences colour his views? In Punjab he was robbed of everything, including his clothes, and, near Ayodhya, nearly sacrificed to goddess Durga by river pirates on the Ganges. Perhaps he was simply a grumpy, irritable monk with a tendency to hastily generalize about lay people. Was he playing to a gallery at home? Or did a kernel of truth, at least sometimes, lie beneath his sweeping pronouncements?